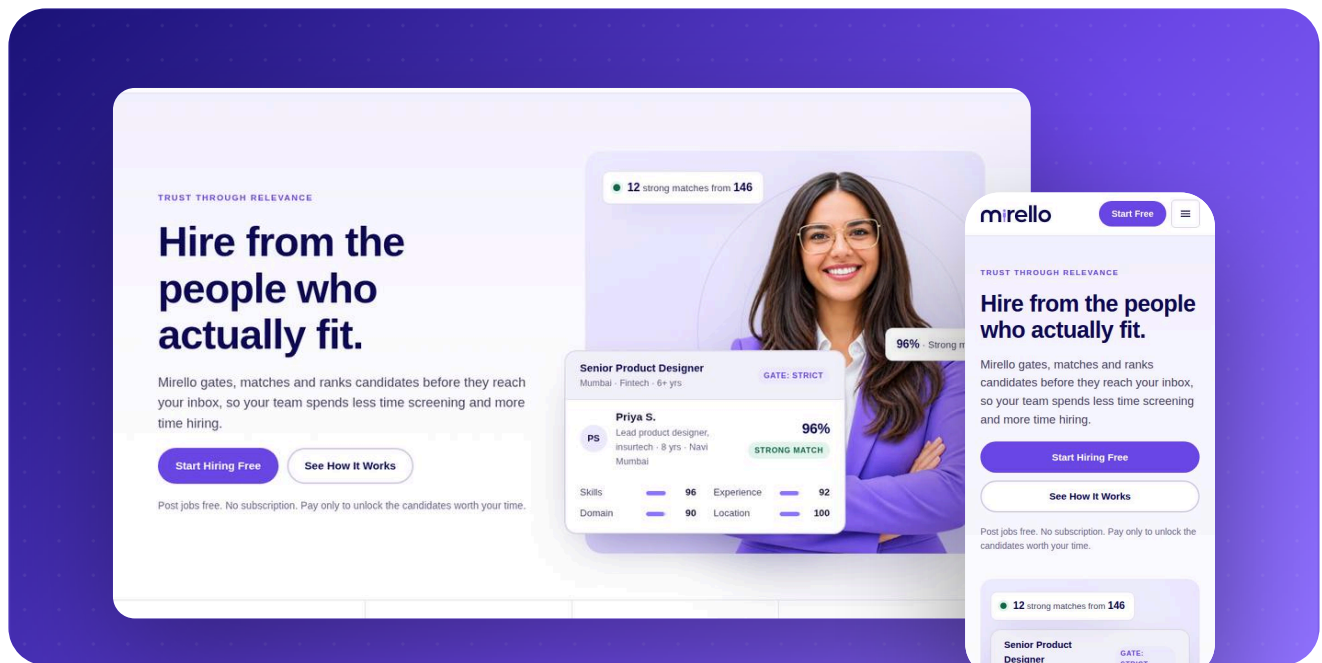


Designing Mirello, a fit-first hiring platform, from brand deck to live demo.

A proof-of-concept engagement: how a startup with two decks and an idea became a positioned product story, a design-system foundation, and a fully built, accessible marketing site with a working demo — in one focused sprint.



Summary

Mission

Mirello's founders had a clear thesis: most hiring platforms sell volume, and recruiters drown in it. Mirello would gate and match candidates *before* they apply, explain every score, and charge only for the candidates a recruiter chooses to unlock. What they had was a brand deck, a sales deck and an AI-generated landing page — three artefacts with three different visual identities. What they didn't have was a product story a recruiter could understand in five seconds, or a foundation a team could build on.

My contributions

I ran this as a proof of concept, end to end and solo — with Claude AI as my working partner throughout: platform strategy and a competitive map of eight Indian hiring platforms; a design-system audit and architecture; UX strategy, information architecture and wireframes for a 16-section homepage; the high-fidelity desktop build and responsive adaptation; and an accessibility audit before shipping a public demo the

Client

Mirello — early-stage hiring platform, India

Proof of concept. This engagement produced a positioned product story, design-system foundations and a working demo site. It is not a shipped commercial product, and the metrics on this page describe the design work, not market results.

Skills

- Product & platform strategy
- Competitive research
- Design-system audit & architecture
- UX strategy, IA & wireframes
- UI design & front-end build

founders could share the same day. Every stage produced a decision the next one depended on — strategy first, pixels last.

Impact

Because this is a POC and not a live commercial product, there are no traffic or revenue numbers to report — and I'd rather not invent any. What the sprint produced: a positioned product story, a design-system foundation, and a fully built, accessible demo site the founders could share the same day.

- Accessibility audit (WCAG 2.2 AA)
- AI-assisted workflow (Claude)

My role

Principal Product Designer — strategy, UX, UI, design system and build.

Tools

Claude (Anthropic) via Cowork & MCP · HTML/CSS · axe-core · Figma

Timeline

One sprint, September 2026

Strategy first, pixels last.

I resisted the urge to open Figma. Each stage produced a decision the next one depended on.

01 Platform strategy and competitive map

Read the decks for what they committed the product to: pre-apply gating, semantic matching with an explainable breakdown, pay-per-unlock, referrals. Mapped the landscape in four tiers — volume incumbents, curated tech platforms, ATS tools that would absorb "AI matching" as a feature, and the agencies whose 8–20% fees the ₹199 unlock quietly undercuts. Key insight: matching would become a commodity. The defensible layer was marketplace behaviour and the pricing model.

02 Design-system audit

Inventoried all four sources across 16 element categories. The sales deck ran on an unrelated teal-and-coral palette. The AI landing page was a retinted template with 14 hardcoded hex values, no form labels and no focus states. The finding that mattered: white text on the brand violet #9173FF measured 3.44:1, failing WCAG AA on every primary button in every source.

03 UX strategy, IA and wireframe

Built the page around one principle — signal over volume — and a trust ladder: is this just another job board? does the matching actually work? what does it cost to find out? Sixteen sections answer those three doubts in that order. Every heading was written before any layout, so the page still makes sense to someone who reads only headlines.

04 High-fidelity build, then responsive

Built the desktop page directly in HTML and CSS on the token foundation, iterated on the sections that carried the most weight, then adapted for 768 and 390 without shrinking the desktop layout.

05 Audit, harden, ship

Ran axe-core at desktop and mobile widths, keyboard-walked the page, fixed what came up, added SEO structure, and deployed to a public bucket so the founders could share it the same day.

Eight Indian platforms, one gap.

I didn't want Mirello to be another Naukri or LinkedIn clone. So before designing anything I looked at what each platform actually sells recruiters, and where Mirello could be meaningfully different rather than marginally better.

Naukri / Resdex	Massive database. Don't compete on size — compete on quality before access and transparent fit.
LinkedIn Recruiter	Network plus sourcing. Compete on job-specific fit evidence, not networking.
Instahyre	The closest benchmark. Go further: pre-application gating, explainable scoring, pay per relevant contact.
Cutshort	Sourcing marketplace. Offer a structured fit model, score transparency and hiring intelligence.
Foundit · Apna · Shine · Hrist	Volume portals and vertical players. Own professional-hiring quality, explainable semantic matching, and fit-first hiring beyond tech.

What the landscape told me. Every platform optimises for more: more applications, more profiles, bigger databases, more filters. Nobody tells the candidate why they didn't fit, and nobody shows the recruiter the evidence behind a score. That became the positioning I recommended over "another AI recruitment platform": *the hiring platform that shows you who is actually worth interviewing*. Or shorter — hire from signal, not volume.

Five product principles that came out of it

Don't show recruiters 500 candidates.

Show "12 candidates worth your time." The first screen answers "who should I interview and why?"

Let the recruiter define fit.

Must-have, strong preference, nice-to-have, deal-breakers, and a strictness slider from flexible to strict.

Design around decisions, not features.

JD → match → evidence → decision, without ten screens in between.

Make the score explainable.

Skills, experience, recency, trajectory, location — each visible, plus a plain-language "why this candidate".

Candidate evidence, not candidate cards.

Matched criteria, gaps, a quoted proof point, availability, expected compensation, fit confidence.

Who we were designing for.

There was no budget or time for primary interviews in a one-sprint POC, so I built proto-personas from three sources and treated them as hypotheses to validate, not facts. They were still enough to settle every argument about what goes above the fold.

SOURCE 01

The founders' decks

Sales and brand decks encode who the founders had already spoken to: TA leads drowning in volume, and the ₹199 unlock priced against agency fees. I read them as field notes.

SOURCE 02

Eight competitor teardowns

What each platform sells, what its reviews complain about, and which recruiter jobs-to-be-done nobody serves — the "why didn't I fit?" question on the candidate side above all.

SOURCE 03

Domain experience

Eighteen years inside BFSI and enterprise SaaS teams, on both sides of hiring, plus the recruiters I've sat next to through PI planning. Not a substitute for research; a good place to start it.

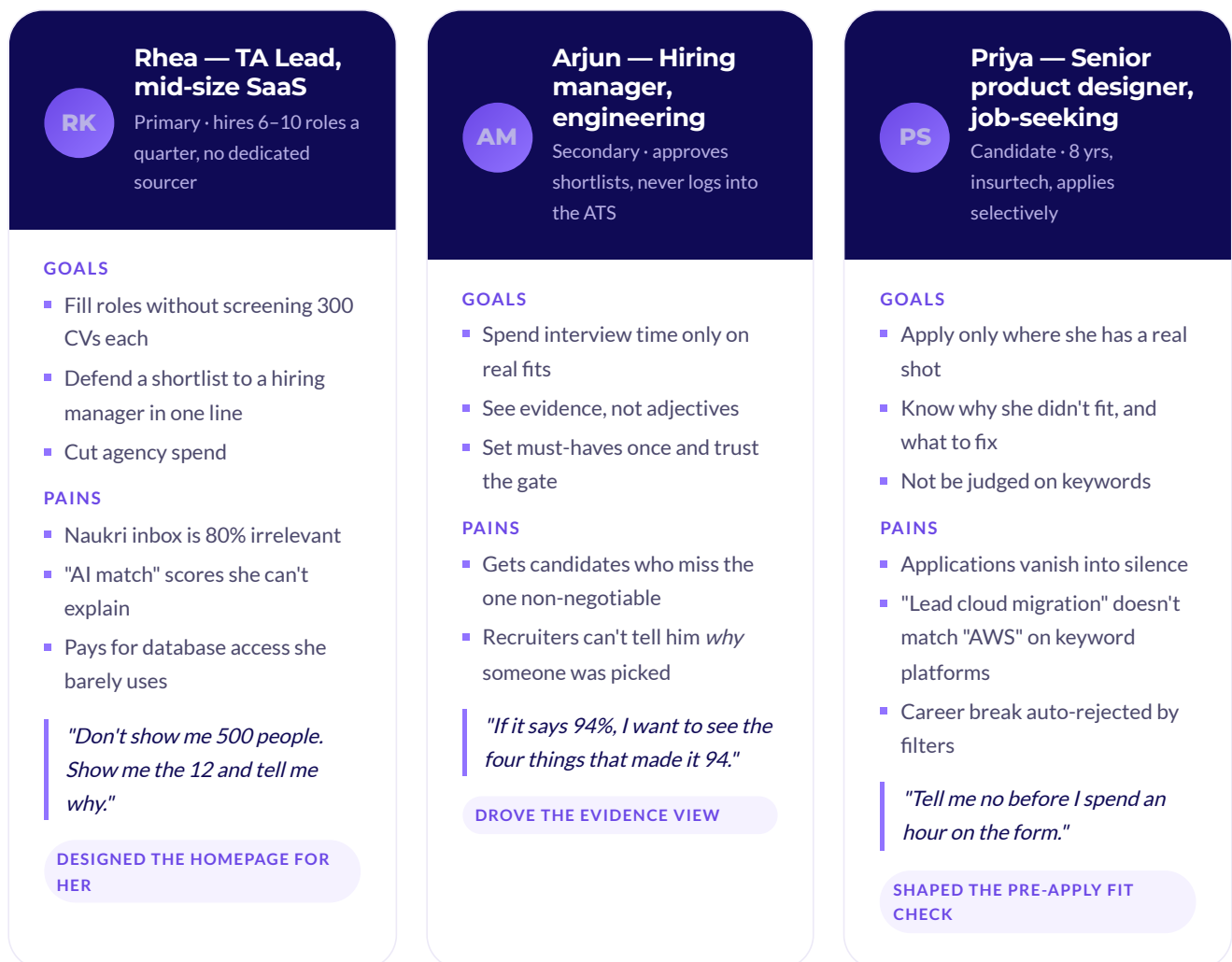
01 Volume is the problem, not a feature. Every incumbent sells "more candidates". A TA lead's real question is "who should I interview today?"

02 Scores without reasons don't earn trust. Recruiters have been burned by keyword matching. A number they can't explain to a hiring manager is worthless.

03 Candidates want feedback more than reach. Applying into silence is the single most-cited complaint in candidate reviews across the platforms studied.

04 Pricing has to feel like buying evidence, not a subscription. Pay only when you unlock someone worth talking to — the model the decks committed to, and the one that undercuts agencies.

Three proto-personas



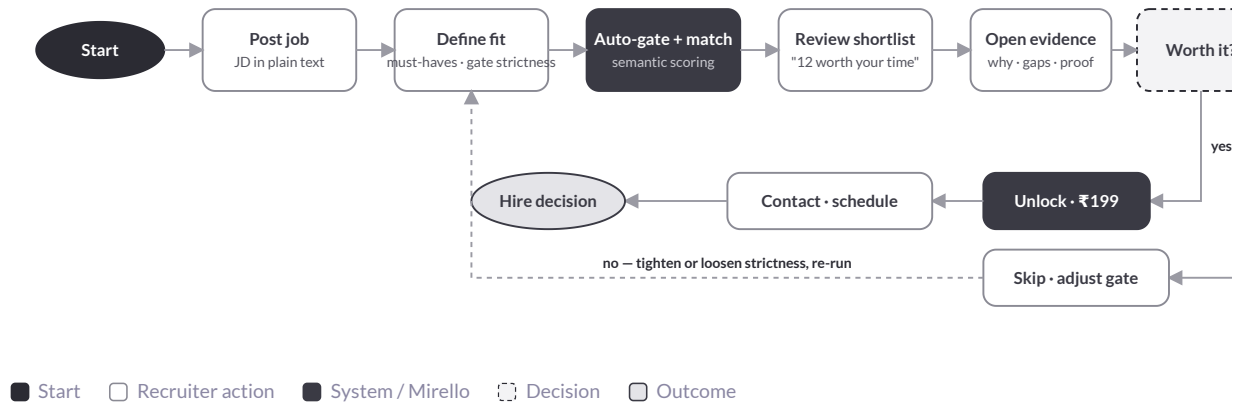
Priya is the candidate shown in the homepage hero — the persona and the product screen were designed together so the demo tells one consistent story.

Three flows, one gate.

The whole product turns on one moment: fit is checked *before* a candidate lands in a recruiter's inbox. Every flow passes through that gate, which is why the homepage could explain the product in a single diagram.

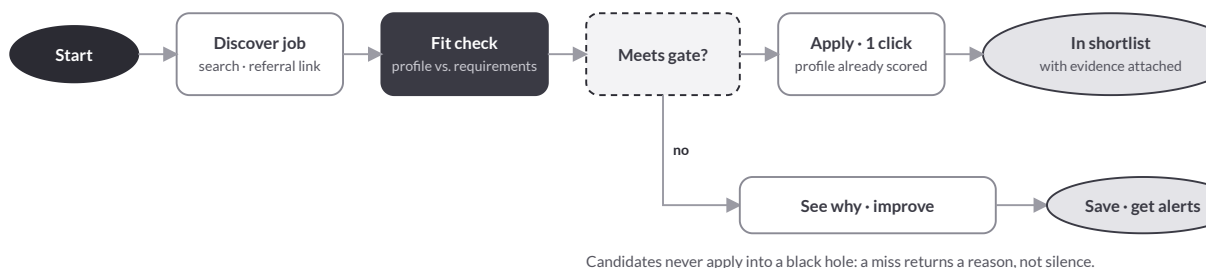
Recruiter — from job post to hiring decision

Define fit once, let the system gate and score, review only the strong matches, pay per unlock. The loop back lets a recruiter loosen or tighten strictness without re-posting.



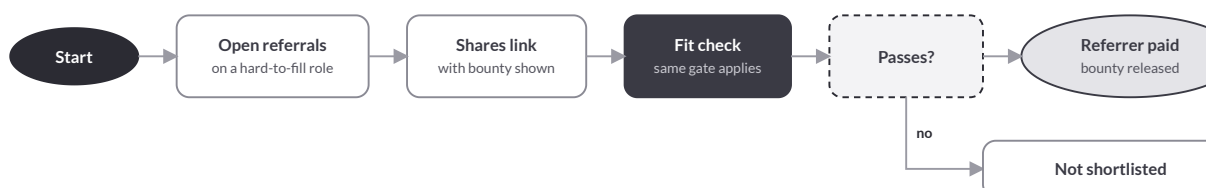
Candidate — fit check before the form

A candidate sees whether they clear the gate before investing in an application. A miss returns a reason and what would change it, which is the feedback the incumbents never give.



Referral — the same gate, with a bounty

Referrals don't bypass fit. A referred candidate goes through the identical check, so the shortlist stays clean and the referrer is paid only on a hire.



What the flows decided. Because every path converges on the gate, the homepage's "How Mirello works" section shows exactly three screens — Post & Define Fit, Auto-Gate & Match, Review & Unlock — and the pricing appears inside the third one. The flows are also why "Define fit" got the strictness slider: it's the only control a recruiter needs to change outcomes without starting over.

Two documents the team can keep using.

mirello

DESIGN SYSTEM

01 Audit & architecture

02 Foundations

03 Token architecture

04 Primitives

05 Core components

06 Composite components

07 Enterprise patterns

08 Accessibility

09 Responsive + theming

10 Figma + developer docs

11 Governance

12 Quality audit

Phase brief

Sources audited

UI inventory

Color findings

Typography findings

Spacing, radius, elevation

Component findings

Consistency findings

Inconsistency register

PHASE 1 OF 12

Design System Audit & Architecture

Product Mirello, fit-first hiring platform Status: Audit complete, awaiting sign-off

Version 0.1.0 Date: 7 Sep 2026

OBJECTIVE

Inventory every visual and interaction decision that exists today across the brand identity, the sales deck, the slash landing page and the homepage prototype, so that Phase 2 builds on what's real instead of inventing a parallel system.

WHAT THIS PHASE CREATES

- UI inventory of all four sources
- Findings by category with severity
- Inconsistency register (kept, not identity fixed)
- Eight-layer system architecture
- Naming conventions, agreed before any tokens are written

DECISIONS MADE

- The brand identity deck is the source of truth for color and type. The sales deck and slash page are not.
- Nothing is deleted. Conflicts are logged in the register and resolved in Phase 2 with you.
- The homepage prototype's token names are a draft, not the final schema.

DEPENDENCIES & OPEN ISSUES

- Primary violet fails AA for white text at 3.6:1. Needs a decision before Phase 2 (see Color).
- No product UI exists yet (onboard dashboard, match list, candidate flow). The audit covers marketing surfaces only: enterprise components in Phases 5 to 7 will be not new.
- Launch market (India vs Australia) affects currency, date and phone formats in tokens and content rules.

Sources audited

SOURCE	WHAT IT IS	AUTHORITY	NOTES
Brand identity deck (22 PDF)	Logos, palette, values, applications	SOURCE OF TRUTH	Defined many colors, charcoal, light grey. Monogram for signage. Lots for poster copy for UI components
Sales deck (9 slides, PDF)	Investor / customer pitch	CONTENT ONLY	Built on a different visual system entirely (trial, coral, slate, Caller). Pricing and feature copy are authoritative; visuals are not.
Slash landing page (code.html + screen.png)	AI-generated marketing page	NOT A REFERENCE	A retained third-party template ("Tailor"). Winning terms, hand-coded fix, placeholder copy about legal services. Useful only as a list of things to avoid.
Homepage prototype (mirello-homepage.html)	Recruiter-first marketing page built this session	DRAFT	Already token-driven with light and dark themes. Chosen thing to a starting point, but its token names and static colors need revision.
Logo package (PDF + PNG)	Final wordmark	SOURCE OF TRUTH	Vector confirms exact hex: #8F562D, violet #8F78FF. Two 90 rules (honors for letters, even/odd for the "o" and the "y" figure).

UI inventory

What exists today, per source. A dash means the source doesn't contain that element at all, which for the product UI categories is the case everywhere: there are no tables, modals, toasts, empty states or loading states anywhere yet.

Design System, Phase 1 — audit, inconsistency register, eight-layer architecture and naming conventions, written before a single token existed.

11	Referrals	Secondary capability, kept short	---	---
12	Pricing	Free to start; pay per relevant unlock	Pricing	Start Hiring Free
13	Candidate value	Supply-side message, one screen	For Candidates	Create Your Profile
14	FAQ	Evaluator objections	---	---
15	Final CTA	Last ask, both CTAs	---	Start Hiring Free · Book a Demo
16	Footer	Sitemap, legal, tagline	---	---

Navigation maps to five anchors (Product, How It Works, For Recruiters, For Candidates, Pricing) plus Log In and the primary CTA. No dropdowns on the homepage: everything is on this page.

3. Content hierarchy

Read only the headings and the page should still make sense. This is the skimmer's path:

LEVEL	COPY	SECTION
H1	Hire from the people who actually fit.	02
H2	Your team shouldn't have to screen hundreds of people to find five good ones.	04
H2	Meet Fit-First Hiring.	05
H2	Three steps from job post to interview.	06
H2	Don't just show a score. Show why.	07
H2	See it work, step by step.	08
H2	Built differently, on purpose.	09
H2	Less Screening. More Hiring.	10
H2	Your network can help you hire.	11
H2	Start here. Pay only for the unlocks worth it.	12
H2	Know if you fit before you apply.	13
H2	Questions recruiters ask us.	14
H2	Ready to spend less time screening?	15

Section 03 (proof) and 16 (footer) carry no H2; they're supporting furniture. "Trust Through Relevance" is used as the eyebrow above the H1 rather than as a heading, because it's a brand line, not a claim a visitor can act on. "Hire Smarter. Not Harder" is relied from the homepage; it's the sales deck's line and it says less than the H1 does.

4. Section-by-section wireframe (desktop, 1280)

Greyscale schematic. Solid dark = primary action; third grey = product UI module; dashed = content block. Each comes with the seven rationale points the brief asks for.

Homepage strategy and wireframe — IA, content hierarchy, a greyscale wireframe per section with rationale, conversion map and responsive plan.

Where the design earned its keep.

COLOUR

Keep the brand violet, add an action violet

Rather than abandon #9173FF or switch buttons to navy, I introduced #6B47E6 for actions, links and focus rings. One hex value, brand intact, every button passes AA at 5.72:1.

HERO

The product is the proof

No generic HR stock photo. The hero shows a real match view — 146 applications → 27 qualified → 12 strong — with the top candidate's score breakdown. "Less screening, more relevant" without an adjective.

TRUST

Show why, not just a score

The match-intelligence section became the largest product module on the page: five-dimension breakdown, matched evidence in the recruiter's own words, gaps, and a fit-confidence label. It exists to kill the black-box objection.

HONESTY

No fake proof

No customer logos, no testimonials, no "70% fewer applications" until sourced. Placeholders are labelled as placeholders — the same rule this case study follows.

TYPE

Montserrat above 16px, Lato at and below

Montserrat is wide and eats horizontal space in tables and forms. So it carries display and headings only; buttons, table cells and body sit in Lato.

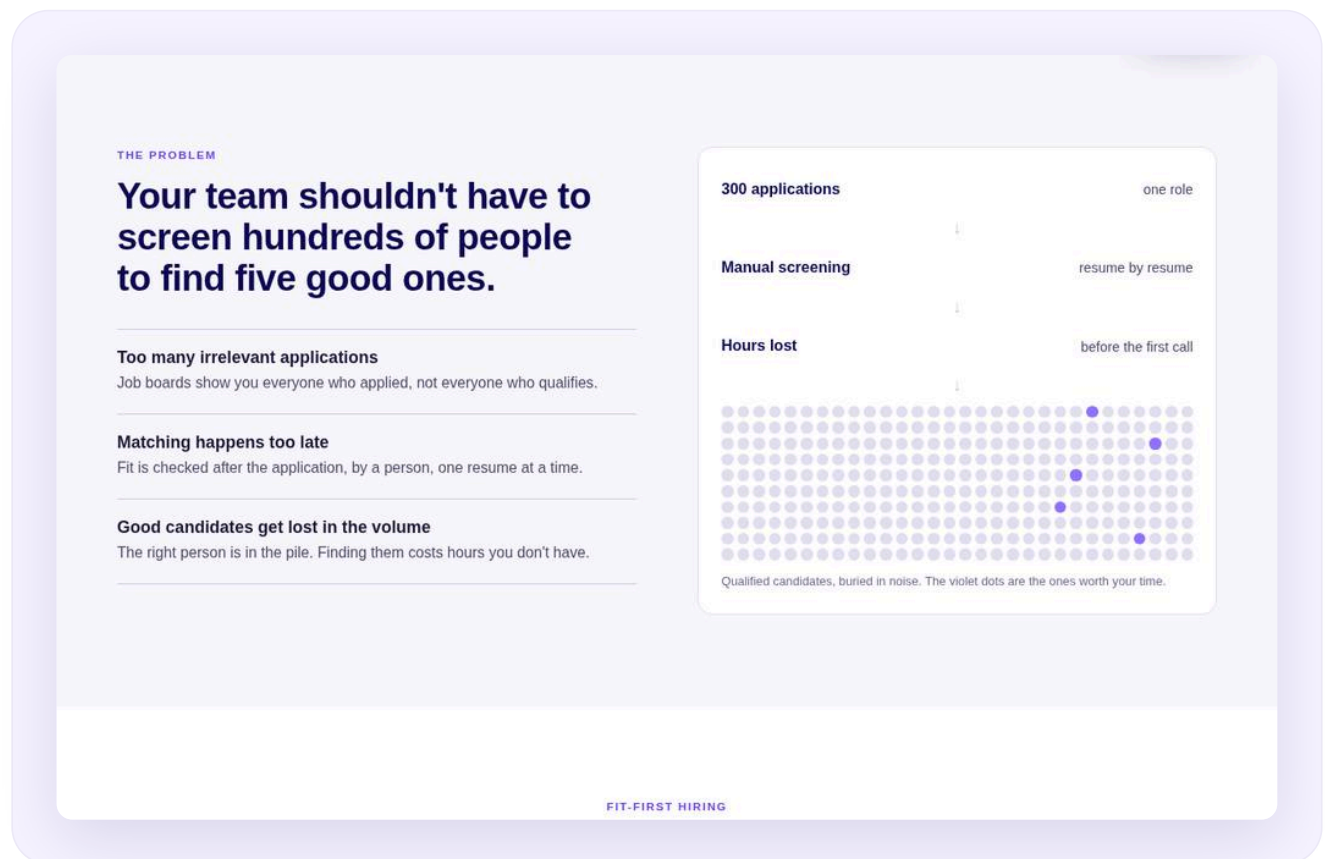
LIGHT ONLY

No dark bands

The founders asked for light backgrounds throughout. Navy became type and two small emphasised surfaces; sections alternate between off-white and a pale violet tint.

Sixteen sections, one question.

Every section answers a specific recruiter doubt. A few of the ones that carried the most weight:



The problem, drawn rather than photographed. Five violet dots in a grid of 300 are the candidates worth a recruiter's time.

HOW MIRELLO WORKS

Three steps from job post to interview.

STEP 01

Post & Define Fit

Tell Mirello what truly matters for this role. You decide how strict the gate is.

Define fit
Senior Product Designer

MUST HAVE	Figma, design systems
PREFERRED	BFSI or insurtech domain
NICE TO HAVE	WCAG accessibility work
DEAL BREAKER	Notice period over 60 days
GATE STRICTNESS	75

STEP 02

Auto Gate & Match

Every candidate is checked against your gate, then scored on meaning, not keywords.

Gate & match
Live for this role

146 applied

27 passed your must-haves

12 strong matches

STEP 03

Unlock & Hire

See ranked matches free. Unlock only the ones worth an interview: full profile, contact details.

Strong matches
Ranked by fit

PS	Priya S. 8 yrs - Navi Mumbai	96%
RK	Rahul K. 6 yrs - Pune	91%
AM	Ananya M. 7 yrs - Bengaluru	88%

Unlock Priya's full profile

Unlock · ₹199

Start Hiring Free

Three real screens, not three icons. The unlock price appears inside the UI so pricing is never a surprise later.

MATCH INTELLIGENCE

Don't just show a score. Show why.

"Led cloud migration" matches "AWS experience" even with no shared words. And every match shows exactly what matched, what's missing, and how confident we are.

94%
STRONG MATCH

FIT CONFIDENCE
HIGH

Skills	96
Relevant experience	92
Skill recency	90
Career trajectory	82
Location fit	100

WHY THIS CANDIDATE?

- ✓ Enterprise SaaS product design, 6 of 8 years
- ✓ Figma, including component libraries
- ✓ Built and maintained a design system
- ✓ BFSI domain: insurance platforms

POTENTIAL GAPS

- ⚠ No direct AI product experience

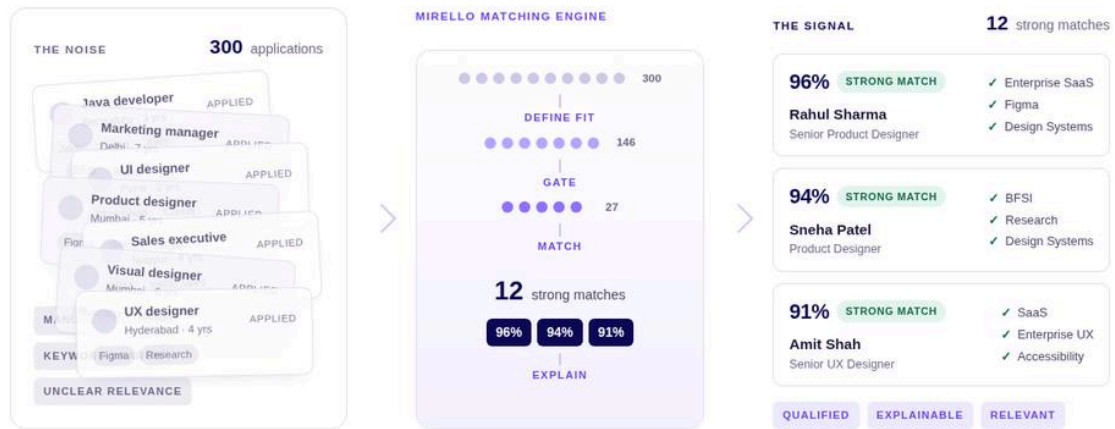
Career breaks and non-linear paths never hard-gate a candidate. They appear only as a soft signal you control.

"Don't just show a score. Show why." The section a sceptical TA lead screenshots for their boss.

WHY MIRELLO

Stop searching through noise. Start seeing who fits.

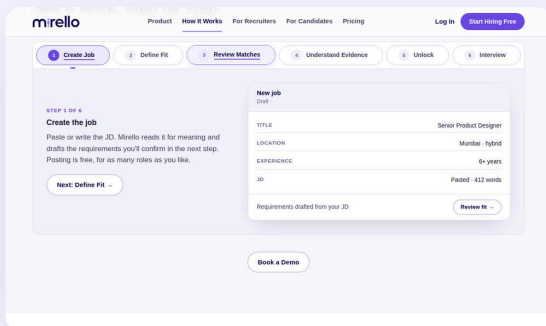
Traditional platforms help you collect candidates. Mirello helps you identify the ones worth talking to.



Traditional platforms optimise for volume.
Mirello optimises for relevance.

- 01 Fit before volume**
Candidates are evaluated against what actually matters.
- 02 Match the meaning**
Go beyond keyword matching with semantic relevance.
- 03 See why they fit**
Every match comes with clear supporting evidence.
- 04 Pay for relevance**
Pay only when you choose to unlock a candidate worth pursuing.

Noise → engine → signal. The competitor comparison rebuilt as a left-to-right story instead of a table.



An interactive six-step walkthrough built as an accessible tabs pattern. Steps restyled as chips after feedback that they didn't read as clickable.



Productivity, second iteration. The first version was two lists that looked identical; the founders sketched this and it was right.

How I used Claude on this project.

This sprint was my first end-to-end build with Claude as a working partner rather than a chat window. I set the direction, made the calls and reviewed everything; Claude did the heavy lifting between decisions. The rule I kept: AI drafts, I decide.

01 Strategy and research, faster

I fed Claude the brand deck and sales deck and had it pull out every commitment the product had already made — gating, explainable matching, pay-per-unlock. Then I used it to map eight Indian hiring platforms against those commitments. I checked each claim, cut what was wrong, and wrote the positioning myself. Days of desk research became an afternoon.

02 The design-system audit and register

Claude inventoried the four sources across sixteen element categories and ran the WCAG contrast maths on nine colour pairs — which is how the 3.44:1 failure on the brand violet surfaced early instead of after the first build. The inconsistency register, layer architecture and naming conventions were drafted with Claude and edited by me, so the founders got a document, not a slide.

03 From wireframe to hi-fi in code, not Figma

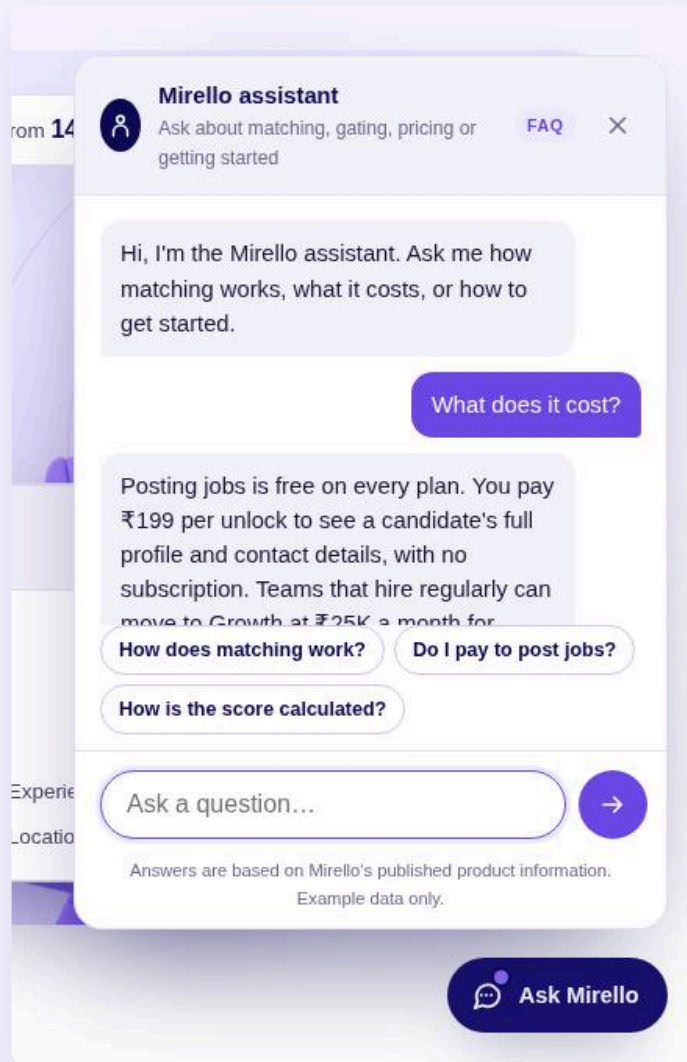
I wrote the sixteen section headings and the rationale for each; Claude built the greyscale wireframe as HTML, then the high-fidelity desktop page on the token foundation, then the 768 and 390 adaptations. Every iteration was a conversation — "the productivity section reads as two identical lists, try the founders' sketch" — and the change came back in minutes. That's why the deliverable is a live demo, not a static mockup.

04 Audit, harden, ship

Claude scripted the axe-core runs at both viewports, the keyboard walk and the target-size check, and fixed the two real issues it found in the same session. It also generated the SEO structure, the og-image and the deployment — the founders had a shareable link the same day.

05 An assistant inside the product

The demo site carries an "Ask Mirello" panel — a Claude-powered assistant grounded only in the page's own product facts, with an FAQ fallback when no AI runtime is available. It lets a sceptical recruiter ask "what does this cost?" and get the pricing answer without hunting for it — and it let the founders see what an AI-native feature could feel like in their product.



"Ask Mirello" — a Claude-powered assistant on the demo site, grounded in the page's product facts.

What it changed. The strategy, the audit, the build and the accessibility pass usually happen in four separate handoffs with four separate tools. With Claude in the loop they happened in one sprint, in one place, with the decisions documented as they were made. What it didn't change: someone still has to know what good looks like, spot the wrong call, and say no. That was my job.